



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 20

MASSACHUSETTS

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Massachusetts's family courts and child-welfare system.

62

MASSACHUSETTS FAMILIES ON
RECORD · 78 CHILDREN IMPACTED ·
19 MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST
OF PARENTING TIME

REPORT GENERATED
MAY 10, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
16 OF 14

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

MASSACHUSETTS AT A GLANCE.

Across 62 Massachusetts families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 78 55 of 62 families reported child counts	MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN \$114,500 median across 27 families reporting 3+ categories	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 19 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 62.9% 37.1% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 62	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.4	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 55 of 62	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 16

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Massachusetts families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02

THE COST OF MASSACHUSETTS FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	32	\$35,000	\$80,338	\$2,570,800
Lost Wages	24	\$25,000	\$189,917	\$4,558,000
Other Court Fees	19	\$2,000	\$2,844	\$54,040
Therapy / Evaluations	18	\$2,000	\$5,599	\$100,775
Reunification Services	17	\$500	\$6,907	\$117,425
GAL Fees	24	\$7,500	\$11,454	\$274,900
Asset Loss ¹	21	\$30,000	—	—
Median Family Burden (27 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	\$114,500	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least \$1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$30,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		19	1.6 yrs
Mean months lost		31	2.6 yrs
Total across all families		955	79.6 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · MASSACHUSETTS

Most families documenting in Massachusetts are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		27	44%
Not provided		18	29%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		6	10%
Case closed: within last 2 years		2	3%
Active case: progress being made		2	3%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		26	42%
Family Court Only		18	29%
Unknown		9	15%
Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF)		5	8%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		2	3%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		16	26%
5 – 10 years		11	18%
3 – 5 years		11	18%
Over 10 years		7	11%
1-3 years		3	5%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		17	27%
Visitation Only		16	26%
50/50 Joint		12	19%
Full Custody		7	11%
Not Applicable		6	10%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Essex		8	13%
Worcester		5	8%
Norfolk		4	6%
Plymouth		4	6%
Middlesex		3	5%
Bristol		2	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		18	29%
High Conflict Divorce		10	16%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		7	11%
Other		6	10%
Other: (Short answer)		6	10%

04 PARENT VOICES — MASSACHUSETTS

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Massachusetts comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



False allegations by my practicing attorney wife in Norfolk County Massachusetts - who knows all the players in the courthouse - had me removed and took my three children 15 months ago. The judges and CPS have done nothing to correct it even with proof that the allegations are [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Financially hundreds of thousands over the years emotionally much greater but not as much as my children we have timed calls and visits and they beg for more time they hide with the phone and don't want to leave the visits it kills me judge mary black and bridgette garbaly james [...]

— MASSACHUSETTS PARENT · MICHAEL

MORE VOICES FROM MASSACHUSETTS

Destroyed and ripped apart a closely bonded family even causing bad health and lord knows what in future, this country, all of us should be ashamed our children are being trafficked and traumatized

— JODI

Ruined their one and only childhood. Turned their head on GAL reporting and the kids, myself reporting abuse.

— MICHELLE

Destroyed a hardworking close loving family I have lost Everything suffering ptsd The Children are in danger

— LIZ

They placed the rights of a man to abuse his family over the rights a mother and her children have to safety.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They have abused children who had already been traumatized by their parent who abused them and their mother and then they were ripped away from a protective parent without notice based on lies and placed with an abuser. Everyone, including DCF has advocated for them to return to [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my kids life is and mine i never got to raise my kids so me being a parent was extinct

— MICHELLE

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The system destroyed a happy and close family without valid reason and caused tremendous trauma and damage to multiple people all based on false allegations all for financial gain

— JODI

Stripped us of everything in order to keep us stuck in the legal system game

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

"To give you an idea of what the last two years have looked like for me: Total Financial Loss: Lost my career and all savings due to false allegations. Restricted Contact: My relationship with my 3-year-old son is limited to video calls that are intentionally ended within [...]"

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They stole shared love between a mother and her children who deeply love each other. They have caused so much mental trauma for both mother and children that its to the point of irreversible harm to everyone involved.

— ISIS

I don't know who I am anymore. I lost myself and my drive to work and be happy. It's so hard when you're constantly being watched and scrutinized for anything you do RIGHT OR WRONG. No due process, No trial. No therapy for my child. Just his father's lies about me and my family.

— NICOLE

taken money from me that prevents me from using for my kids when they're with me and not being able to pay my bills and have stolen all the joy in my life and this affects my kids.

— WALTER

Destroyed and broken my family to cover up medical malpractice of the hospital that almost killed my child.

— KRISTY

While I wish I could say "the system failed us," I have learned that the system was never meant to protect myself or my children.

— COURTNEY

Destroyed us. My children are continuing to decline including my middle school honor role student has faked the last 4 semesters of school. My second oldest has SI. My 6yr old bites his nails down to the skin at the base and pulls out his hair in stress.

— JILL

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Allowed and helped a father abuse and destroy our beautiful innocent little boy and hurt him every single day of his life.

— GABRIELLE

This system has literally destroyed both my children and myself. Oldest has mental health issues, depression etc. middle has major health issues and is being neglected and younger one is getting the worst as he's not even his child....dcf apparently falsely did the dna as my child [...]

— JENNIFER

“DCF and the entities involved dismantled our family—destroying a mother, siblings, and grandmother—and turned a place of education into a hunting ground where children are stalked, held, and taken with police force.”

— LINDA

Judge Ulwick allowed the other side to continue to put in multiple false allegations and emergency orders which she denied over 30 of them. Dragged it out to over 4 years and costed me over \$93,000 and over 50 lost days in work.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Traumatized us both, my daughter is 3 she self harms, I don't trust anyone and I'm extremely depressed I'm in bed crying constantly, I had to quit my job bcuz they kept [] things say to say with no notice

— KRISTY

The system didn't just separate me from my children—it prolonged and reinforced the very patterns of control and emotional harm we were already living through.

— GINA

Justice delayed. Justice denied. Judge and opposing counsel and opposing counsel continue to destroy the first five years of childhood despite being granted a year of primary physical custody.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has caused my family and myself irreparable harm.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Trapped me and I can't get out after they told me to "file for some self respect". Now me and my kids are low income, destabilized from housing, and have had no relief despite repeated pleadings and attempts to protect them.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

Massive disruption to my son's relationship with my whole family.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I fled a domestic situation and moved closer to my family and support system. I'm being penalized for moving and he has been awarded more than he ever had before, and he's now putting on a show of a good father. The GAL said if I moved back closer we could go closer to 50/50. I [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has been the worst 7 years of my life. Courts dont listen to domestic abused victims, blame everything on us. Instead of realizing we are protecting they threaten to put us in jail and fine us.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has ripped me away from my child whom I struggled to have for 10 years and had a rough pregnancy; The child spoke and told drs and others her father hurts her and scared. The system didn't investigate then gave him custody while my child and home was ripped away and I [...]

— FAITH

Complete and utter destruction in just minutes. My daughter is in imminent danger, as a district Judge ruled, but family court continues the terror and agony.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The fraudulent racketeering business that wears the mask of "family" court exposes the underbelly of the serpents that have been running financial systems for centuries. It raped, pillaged, attempted murder, and assassination of any shred of happiness or family I would think [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has dragged us and extorted us in every way possible referred us into pressured therapy usage etc dictated decisions and wasted time that only parents should be making. Extortion to the absolute fullest while using our kids.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



I was falsely accused by my son's father for doing drugs and being unfit. I have always had full custody of my other son I have, the system took 2 brothers away from each other. The system stole my 11 year old from me and my family on all false allegations that I have been [...]

— RACHEL

Used my past as an excuse Refused programs and things that could have had me with my child under mandated supervision 24/7 while obtaining all case plan tasks Got my housing voutire removed and refuse a letter saying ide have a chance to get my son if they have it bak Unstable [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It was devastating to the child, myself and family and the child is in more danger at this time so why do we have court system failing to protect kids. I was so naive to trust that the court system respects laws or has due process, it is basically the most terrifying display of [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Atty Larry Kelly is a dirty liar. He took an oath to be ethical and he is far from it. He makes up lies and amps up his clients making them worst abusers than they already were. Carry's no malpractice insurance because he's already been disbarred twice. He's an active alcoholic [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I struggled with substance abuse. My father stole custody by coercing me to sign temporary custody. My father is using my son as his second chance to be a father as he wasn't in my life as a child. Court takes extremely long to be heard and just as long to make a decision. [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This situation has caused long term emotional confusion, insecurity, and distress due to the sudden, unjust disruption of a primary bond at a young age, (4) compounded by years of instability and unsubstantiated, conflicting narratives that deprived us of a normal relationship [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has separated us from my granddaughter and we had her since she was three they told her away! We have missed milestones with her and she has missed out on family time with her maternal side. He alienates her against us and there is no truth to anything he tells her. I [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

40 Massachusetts parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 40 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — MASSACHUSETTS

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Massachusetts families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

False allegations by my practicing attorney wife in Norfolk County Massachusetts - who knows all the players in the courthouse - had me removed and took my three children 15 months ago. The judges and CPS have done nothing to correct it even with proof that the allegations are false.

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Financially hundreds of thousands over the years emotionally much greater but not as much as my children we have timed calls and visits and they beg for more time they hide with the phone and don't want to leave the visits it kills me judge mary black and bridgette garbaly james are child abusers I have never done anything and they are profiting off my list time with my children I'm an open book no police record just false accusations with no evidence I have proved my innocence over and over the accusations keep switching

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05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

They have abused children who had already been traumatized by their parent who abused them and their mother and then they were ripped away from a protective parent without notice based on lies and placed with an abuser. Everyone, including DCF has advocated for them to return to my custody without any success or any findings against me. I have a thriving and happy 4 year old in my current marriage and two 14 year old step daughters and yet I can't even speak to my 15 and 16 year old kids who have advocated to come home to me and DCF has a neglect case against their father.

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— RACHEL

Used my past as an excuse Refused programs and things that could have had me with my child under mandated supervision 24/7 while obtaining all case plan tasks Got my housing voutire removed and refuse a letter saying ide have a chance to get my son if they have it bak Unstable housing Pt1 denial Failed parent psych evaluation even tho I passed one 3 years prior Medicallybill due to the trauma of this removal

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I struggled with substance abuse. My father stole custody by coercing me to sign temporary custody. My father is using my son as his second chance to be a father as he wasn't in my life as a child. Court takes extremely long to be heard and just as long to make a decision. Decisions are basically to keep doing the same thing. I've been clean since 2017.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This situation has caused long term emotional confusion, insecurity, and distress due to the sudden, unjust disruption of a primary bond at a young age, (4) compounded by years of instability and unsubstantiated, conflicting narratives that deprived us of a normal relationship for 4 years. Both my daughter, our extended family, and I continue to experience lingering grief, anxiety, and separation anxiety, with the pain of missing each other persisting through long stretches of time apart ... impacts will remain part of our emotional landscape forever. -Anonymous, Utah

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has separated us from my granddaughter and we had her since she was three they told her away! We have missed milestones with her and she has missed out on family time with her maternal side. He alienates her against us and there is no truth to anything he tells her. I don't even think she is allowed to speak of us. We send certified mail every week with a card and puzzles or little treats for two 1/2years since we haven't seen her. I'm sure she's not getting any of it because it's not being given to her.!!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

40 full approved Massachusetts comments are included in this appendix.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Massachusetts report comes from Massachusetts respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Massachusetts — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 62 Massachusetts families reporting here are not the universe of Massachusetts families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte-Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

[STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com) · COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE

ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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